PORTLAND PUBLIC SCHOOLS
501 North Dixon Street
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Date: June 24, 2025

To: PPS Board of Education

From: Deborah Kafoury, Chief of Staff
Kat Davis, Advisor for Climate Justice

Subject: **Climate Crisis Response Policy Annual Update and Recommendations**

Introduction

The purpose of this memo is to provide an annual update on the implementation of the Climate Crisis Response, Climate Justice and Sustainable Practices Policy (CCRP) (APPENDIX A). This memo will review high-level progress made on policy implementation, successes, challenges, and recommendations to meet the ambitious goals in our commitment to the community. A comprehensive annual report will be provided in the Fall, including comprehensive data from the 24-25 school year, emissions reduction metrics, and a strategic plan for 25-26 reflecting community needs and Board priorities.

Context

In March 2022, the Portland Public Schools Board of Education (the Board) unanimously adopted the Climate Crisis Response, Climate Justice, and Sustainable Practices Policy. This policy commits PPS to immediately mobilize resources to reduce the impact of climate change. Beyond responsibility for greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions, the policy centers frontline communities[1] in advancing climate resilience, developing a climate justice education, and to connect students, parents, teachers, staff, and community partners as leaders in climate solutions. This policy requires the advancement of District planning to consider the disproportionate impacts of climate change on the vulnerable members of our community, and recognizes our responsibility to attend to our students' mental health, wellness and emotional challenges that come from anticipating and experiencing extreme climate events. With this commitment, PPS can show our students what a future of climate solutions looks like, creating opportunities for excellence despite a changing climate.

To advance the CCRP objectives, PPS continued to strengthen an intentional and focused strategic approach, with particular attention to the Climate Crisis Response Committee 2023-

[1] Communities that experience the 'first and worst' impacts of climate change: those experiencing systemic injustice—including people of color, people with disabilities, immigrants, people with lower incomes, those in rural areas, and indigenous people—and face a legacy of systemic inequity that impacts their living and working places, the quality of their air and water, and their economic opportunities.

2024 Annual Report recommendations:

I. Make CCRP Dashboard publicly available on the PPS website by Fall 2024 to **enhance transparency and community engagement.**
II. **Increase capacity** for Policy implementation
III. Pursue **additional funding sources** to advance implementation of the Policy.
IV. More effectively **reach students about climate related opportunities** and **expand pathways** for students to get involved.

Given limited resources, prioritization of the 75+ objectives within the Climate Crisis Response Policy (CCRP) is critical to ensure alignment with leadership's vision and operational capacity. To support these priorities, the Climate Justice Advisor created a high-level framework to prioritize the implementation of systems-wide policy scopes and to establish a district-wide process for tracking progress. The strategic priorities for 2024-25 included:

- Develop a Roadmap for Decarbonization
- Increase accessibility to climate action and student empowerment
- Enhance climate literacy

With the budget reductions for FY26, policy advancement will need to be even more carefully aligned with district-wide initiatives to continue making towards our goals.

Major Milestones Achieved in 2024–2025

In 2024-2025, PPS achieved the following milestones towards strategic implementation of policy scopes:

- Completion of the Decarbonization Prioritization Tool (APPENDIX II)
  - Advances CCRP Objectives: 1.1.1, 1.1.2, 1.1.3, 1.1.4, 1.1.7
  - In progress: systemic operationalization of utilizing tool

- Published the Climate Action Design Team Report (APPENDIX III)
  - Advances CCRP Objectives: 3.3.1, 3.3.2, 3.3.3, 3.3.4
  - In progress: Climate Justice Engagement, Empowerment Best Practices

- Published the PPS Climate Literacy Assessment (APPENDIX IV)
  - Advances CCRP Objectives: 3.1.1, 3.2.1, 3.2.2, 3.3.3
  - In progress: Mapping K-12 Climate Literacy Arc

Concurrently, PPS has made progress towards the following CCRC Recommendations:

I. **Enhance transparency and community engagement** by making Policy Dashboard publicly available

- Complete: accessible at pps.net/climatejustice

II. **Increase capacity** for Policy implementation
   - Utilized Portland Clean Energy Funds (PCEF) grant funding to hire a Climate Justice Student Projects Coordinator
   - Strategic prioritization allows increased capacity for focused progress on student engagement and empowerment

III. Pursue **additional funding sources** more aggressively
   - $25.8M - PCEF Collaborating for Climate Action grant for infrastructure (result is $40M from PCEF for infrastructure total)
   - $99,075.48 - Oregon Dept of Land Conservation and Development, Community Green Infrastructure grant for Green Schoolyards
   - $100,000 - Oregon Dept of Ed, Farm to Child Nutrition Program
   - Continued advocacy at legislative level

IV. More effectively **reach students about climate related opportunities** and **expand pathways** for students to get involved.

   - Increased support and engagement of Climate Justice Youth Advisory
   - With PCEF Student-Led Projects Funds, nearly 700 students across 34 schools are now leading climate projects. These student-led efforts– ranging from clean air advocacy to creating climate-focused children's books–highlight the power of youth-driven action and learning.

Moving Forward

As we refine our focus to advance student excellence, we are building on the strategic priorities identified during the foundational year of policy implementation (2022–2023): Coordinated and Effective Leadership, Inclusive, Collaborative and Data-Driven Decision-Making, and Strategic Advocacy and Allocation of Resources. In FY25, these priorities are more vital than ever, guiding us as we thoughtfully align our resources and strengthen our administrative capacity to ensure continued progress and equitable outcomes for all students.

Moving forward, the PPS Climate Justice Advisor will compile the comprehensive 2024-2025 annual report and take the Climate Crisis Response Committee recommendations into consideration to develop a strategic implementation proposal for PPS leadership for the 2025-2026 school year.